



Phone Etiquette

"This 'telephone' has too many shortcomings to be seriously considered as a means of communication. The device is inherently of no value to us."

—Western Union internal memo, 1876.

The telephone has always been a beast of burden for business communication. Even some of the iconic images of last century's business world revolve around the phone—a serious businessman busily talking on the phone, a secretary taking down a phone message for the boss and the army of telephone operators (who were a subculture unto themselves) connecting phone lines and people. But, what used to be a simple instrument (with an annoying ringtone) tethered to your desks, has now evolved into a sophisticated gadget with all sorts of multimedia communication capabilities, elaborate storage possibilities with a number of organizer and productivity features besides being mobile so that you can carry it and use it almost anywhere in the world. The Blackberries, iPhones, 3G and what have you, have all ushered in an exciting era of communications, giving you many more choices (and many more annoying ringtones) and many novel ways to conduct business communication.

Once only in the hands of the elite—at least in India—phones have now percolated down to all strata of society the world over and are integrating entire humanity in a complex network of communication channels, making it possible for almost anyone to reach anyone else, anywhere in the world, at any time—a perfect pill for today's globalized business. Alexander Graham Bell may have invented the telephone. But, we are still discovering it and trying to come up with even newer applications for telephony.

India by and large missed the telecom and telephony revolution of the mid 20th Century. The good side of it is that India is not left with much of legacy baggage to carry on; a large number of Indians did not have to handle those brick-sized mobile phones, did not use answering machines and pagers, but simply leapfrogged into the mobile revolution. Indians have been quick to adapt to text messaging ('SMS-ing') and what is popularly called 'MCC' (missed call citizen), something a lot of older generation Americans loathe doing even now.

The bad side is that the legal aspects and etiquette of using telephones (at least as expected in a globalized business environment) have not been inculcated enough into the average Indian professional. Since we are in the 'catch-up' mode, most of us don't make the time to educate ourselves on these things. Instead, we prefer to go about our phone-business in an instinctive manner or pick up bits and pieces of information (some of it patently wrong) from a variety of sources, including hearsay. In this chapter, we will look at some of the standard business practices and telephone protocols that almost the entire world follows. At a microscopic level, this chapter will also talk about personal phone etiquette and how you can groom yourself into having a great 'telephone personality'. This can be a powerful asset in your soft skills portfolio and can make you a valuable member and a spokesperson of any international team.

31.1 WHAT IS A GOOD 'PHONE PERSONALITY'?

Phone communication is a form of synchronous communication. We have all the advantages and disadvantages of synchronous communications that we discussed in Chapter 13. Just to summarize these here,

- ▶ Since it occurs in real time, you will get immediate responses
- ▶ You would be able to get insights about the recipient and be able to alter your flow.
- ▶ The 'out of sight'-edness of the other party can actually embolden you and help you get over your inhibitions. You may actually ask the boss about that bonus on the phone, whereas you may get tongue-tied and scared when he is actually, physically present in front of you.
- ▶ You can be freer as it is not always as formal as written communication.

But the major disadvantage is that it is not a face-to-face communication. Hence, we are left without the benefit of the important medium of body language. This can be a major handicap especially if you (or the other party) don't know the language very well and rely on body language. A good 'phone personality' can compensate for this shortcoming and can make our communication effective.

And what is a good phone personality? (Box 31.1) It is characterized by *courtesy* and *professionalism* during the call and *dependable follow through* after the call.

The basic expectation in any business phone call is that you be totally and unconditionally courteous and create a nice setting for a pleasant conversation and a

possible business transaction. This means no sulking, no expressions of irritation and no caustic or sarcastic remarks and definitely no arguing or quarrelling with the party at the other end. It doesn't matter whether you are talking to your client or your vendor, your manager or a colleague way too junior to you; and it doesn't matter whether you are having a rough day at work; it doesn't matter who is right and who is wrong—you will have to display utmost courtesy on the phone. It is okay to disagree, but not okay to be disagreeable, especially on the phone! A good phone personality is *always* courteous, no matter what.

Professionalism in a call demands that you provide the information expected of you, address the things you are supposed to address and make commitments that you are authorized to make. But you do not take on-the-fly executive decisions or change project parameters during a private one-on-one phone call. Business phone calls have their limits and are no substitutes for a full blown project meeting. A good phone personality always maintains professionalism and knows where the line is between what he can and cannot commit to do.

A phone call is a part of the communication cycle, as described in Chapter 13. It is not a silo or an end into itself. A call can result in action items that need to be diligently followed through. A good phone personality always takes these action items to completion.

Box 31.1

Some Indicators of Good Phone Personality

While you cannot drastically change your voice and make it very musical, you have to hone your voice and make sure your voice modulation is pleasant to be a good phone personality. The problem with most of us is that we have never taken the trouble to listen to a recording of our own voices and see what we can do to improve it. So it helps to make a short recording of your voice and nudge it toward the right pitch. Some of the questions you should ask yourself about your voice, diction and conversation style are:

- ▶ How is your accent sounding?
- ▶ Can you make it more neutral and lively?
- ▶ Are you too loud or too soft?
- ▶ Are you stressing the right part of the sentence and are you putting in emotion, energy and exuberance into your diction?
- ▶ Since you are going to be invisible to the other person, what are the audible cues you will be giving (in the absence of body language cues)—the smirks, the laughs and the 'hmmm's, the interjections—how do they sound?

- ▶ Do you practise active listening and does the other person know that?
- ▶ Do you let the other person in on the conversation?
- ▶ Do you pepper your speech with enough humour and personal comments that relieve the monotony and keep the conversation interesting?
- ▶ Do you address the other person by his or her name often in the conversation?
- ▶ Is your conversation going in the right direction or is it meandering and waffling?
- ▶ Do you steer clear of controversies and proprietary matters?

Also, here are some things that you shouldn't do as a good phone personality:

- ▶ Don't multitask during a call (like checking e-mail while talking).
- ▶ Don't give the other party the impression that you are in the middle of something or not enthusiastic about the phone call.
- ▶ If more than one person is at the phone at your end, don't get into private conversations while on the call

31.2 ANATOMY OF A BUSINESS PHONE CALL

A business phone call roughly goes through the following steps:

1. Initial greetings
2. Establishing a (virtual) handshake with the other person
3. Getting down to business
4. Summarizing
5. Following through with the minutes of the call
6. Taking the action items to completion.

Let us look at each of these in detail below:

31.2.1 Initial Greetings

If you are answering a phone, basic courtesy demands that you don't let the phone ring till (what appears to be) eternity for the caller. Make it a habit to pick up the phone in no more than 3–5 rings.

When the phone rings and you answer it, do so with a courteous greeting:

- ▶ The universally understood greeting 'Hello' or variations thereof, like 'Hello, this is Ajay of RYZ Corp' or 'Good Morning, this is Ajay' or even 'Hi, this is Ajay Jaiswal' would be appropriate.
- ▶ If you are in a customer service position, an even better way of answering the call would be 'Good morning, this is Ajay of RYZ Corp. How may I assist you?'

- ▶ Don't use a rough-sounding 'Yes?' or 'Yeah?' or 'Jaiswal'. Or worse still, don't keep silent after attending the call, waiting for the other person to start the conversation.

When you initiate a call,

- ▶ Wait for the person at the other end to say 'hello'. It is extremely impolite to start talking even before the other person has had a chance to say hello.
- ▶ After the hello, identify yourself clearly to the person you called—don't presume your voice to be so familiar that people would recognize you right away.
- ▶ If you are making an unscheduled call, preemptively apologize for interrupting and ask them if it is going to be okay to talk for a few minutes. Most people should be okay with a short phone call even if they are busy. As a matter of courtesy, keep your call short and to the point. If they explicitly tell you at the outset that they are too busy, excuse yourself. But, find out when it is convenient for you to call them again and follow through promptly. Likewise, if you need to talk to them at length, find out when best to do so and call them back at a convenient time.

31.2.2 Establishing a Handshake

Establishing the identities of the parties involved in the call is the first part of the virtual handshake of a telephone call. The rest of the handshake is about establishing a rapport and setting the tone (no pun intended) for rest of the conversation.

The first part of the handshake is addressing. If the person at the other end is your customer and you don't know him or her well, address him as Sir or her as Ma'am. If you want to be very formal, you can use the 'Mr Gupta' kind of appellations. A lot of people these days don't mind being addressed by their first names or nicknames—in which case, do so. That might add a personal touch. (Some people may object to being addressed by their first name or nickname—so, be careful about being too informal)

The next part of the handshake is a very brief warm up. A reasonably short 'How are you? How are things out there?' kind of greetings would quickly and effectively provide a natural transition to the main point of the phone call.

31.2.3 Getting Down to Business

After the handshake, comes the main body of the phone call. Here are some general tips:

- ▶ Try to sound cheerful and energetic. Since you have to make do without the help of any body language, your voice should display the cheerfulness and energy.
- ▶ Remember to use a lot of polite words like 'please', 'sorry' and 'thank you'—sometimes even gratuitously.
- ▶ Be especially courteous when interrupting the other person. Make polite interruptive sounds or come up with a 'may I say something?' Don't aggressively butt in.

- ▶ While talking, you and the other party should go back and forth alternately, using short sentences and simple language. No one person should hog the conversation or try to overwhelm the other person.
- ▶ Allow gaps so that the other person can get into the conversation. If what you say is unclear to the other person, repeat it again. If it is still unclear, paraphrase your sentence.
- ▶ Use the methods of active listening described in Chapter 17 to ensure that you and the recipient are in tune.
- ▶ Keep a writing pad next to your phone and take down notes as you speak. String them together as an e-mail and send the other person a copy, just so that there won't be any confusion or misunderstanding later.

Snapshot 31.1

The meat of the conversation is in the middle. Let us say your name is Ajay Jaiswal and you are the quality test engineer at the computer peripherals manufacturer, RYZ Corp. When you interface with your counterpart Mr Rupak Shah, incoming quality test engineer of ECA Computers, you can have all sorts of phone conversations with each other—exchanging technical information, updating informally on the progress made, giving 'heads up' on what is coming, getting related information, etc. Mainly, you can have a serious and lengthy conversation on all the gory technical details ('I got only 4.95 milli-amps of current, when I set it to 5.0 milli-amps. It took me two hours to figure out the problem.')—something you cannot do in a full-blown project meeting, given the time constraints and that you don't want to put everyone else to sleep. You can give Shah partial results of your half-completed testing and he can in turn give you feedback on last week's quality tests and update you on what ECA might do next week in terms of volume and test requirement. This way, you and Shah not only develop a rapport, but also put your minds together to come up with some joint and concerted activities that you can bring to the table in the next project meeting.

31.2.4 Summarizing

The last part of a call is used for summarizing it. Such a summary should cover at a minimum:

- ▶ What is agreed to be done by each party, along with agreed dates
- ▶ Any actions that have to be carried out by other people and how those other people are going to be notified
- ▶ If you are going to formally document the minutes of the call (and we strongly recommend you should), when would that be sent
- ▶ When and how you are going to sync up again to review the follow up actions.

Try to end the conversation on a bright, positive note. A dash of small talk toward the end of the call is good practice. When you finish talking, make sure you actually utter the word 'bye' before ending the call. Just hanging up without a formal 'bye' is considered extremely rude.

31.2.5 Following Through with Minutes

Business phone calls arise out of action items. And they end up generating more action items and requests for information. So, it is important to keep track of these things or they will come back to haunt you. The first action item is that you quickly summarize these phone generated action items into a documented text and send them over by e-mail to the other party—and also a bunch of other team members, just to let them know what transpired. This way it will now become a part of the formal project paperwork. If anything is ambiguous, call Shah right away and resolve the issue. The tips we gave in the chapters on meeting management (Chapter 24) and will discuss in e-mail etiquette (Chapter 32) about writing minutes of meetings are applicable here as well.

A business phone call can also be used to compare your checklist of activities against the other parties checklist and formally close those items which have no loose ends. Again, circulate an e-mail announcing this 'off-line' transaction.

If you are the organizer of a regular conference-call, make sure you send out the minutes of the call as well as the agenda for the next call. And don't forget to reserve the conference room for the next call, should you require it. Again, these are in line with what we discussed in our earlier chapters.

31.2.6 Taking Action Items to Completion

The action items that were committed to during a phone call should be taken to their logical conclusion. If other people or functions are to be involved in executing such action items, make sure that you contact them soon enough and close the loop.

When the action items are taken to completion, acknowledge the people who made it possible. Also, if you have a follow up call, recognize this and document the completion in the minutes of that meeting/call.

Make sure you complete these telephonic action items according to the commitments that were made. If, for some unavoidable reason, you are unable to complete your committed action items in time, do inform the coordinator well ahead, so as not to cause unpleasant surprises.

31.3 CONFERENCE CALL ETIQUETTE

You can also connect several people from across the world to the same call and have an effective multi-pronged conference. International tele-conference or conference

calls are so common place that some people participate in several of them each day. Your effective and active participation in your conference calls is absolutely essential for the success of your project.

Conference calls should be treated exactly like face-to-face meetings. You discuss project status, take decisions, assign activities to team members and so on over the phone, much like you would in a sit-down meeting. Here too, it is important that the meeting agenda are set ahead of time and after the call, minutes are noted down and published—especially the action items, the owners and deadlines.

Though conference calls are similar in intent and direction to a group meeting, they present several unique challenges that you don't see in face-to-face meetings.

- ▶ When a number of people participate in a conference call from different locations around the world, it may be sometimes confusing to figure out who it is that is talking.
- ▶ Accents could be very different, making understanding more difficult.
- ▶ The sound quality can be very poor and add to the confusion.
- ▶ Making interruptions and responding right away can become tricky in a conference call and you may have to try a couple of times before you can get yourself airtime.
- ▶ Time difference could reduce the focus of the participants who are participating in the call at what are unearthly hours for them.

Some of the methods to overcome the above challenges are:

- ▶ Make sure you have good multi directional speaker phones to make it possible for people sitting in far corners of the room to be audible.
- ▶ If you have to dial in any of the participants to the call, make sure you get their numbers correct.
- ▶ If the participants have to dial in themselves to a conferencing centre, make sure you e-mail them the number to be dialled in and any identification mechanism like meeting ID and password.
- ▶ Make sure all the international attendees know the local time in your location by giving your time as an offset from GMT. Make sure you account for any daylight savings.
- ▶ Accents and diction can help identify people sometimes. See if you can tag people based on their accents.
- ▶ When you dial in to the conference number, make sure you introduce yourself and where you are calling from. ('Hi, this is Ajay from Bangalore'). If there are multiple groups within Bangalore, make sure you identify your group as well.
- ▶ Speak even more deliberately and slowly than when you speak in person and only when it is your turn.
- ▶ Whenever you speak, it is a good idea to keep re-introducing yourself several times in the call, just to make sure ('Hi, this is Ajay from Bangalore, again').

- ▶ When you want to interrupt, make sure you choose an appropriate pause and say, 'Hi Ajay here again, I would just add to this point by . . .'.
- ▶ If you find the person speaking currently is not giving any chance to others by continuous, non-stop talking, you can interrupt gently by saying 'John . . . John . . . this is Ajay here, can I interrupt you for a minute?'
- ▶ Don't be shy about asking a speaker to repeat or re-affirm things if you didn't hear or understand what he said. It is wiser and more effective to ask him to repeat and get a common understanding than making wrong assumptions.
- ▶ Be very patient with people who are not particularly articulate or phone-savvy and try to help them by paraphrasing sentences. (But be careful about putting wrong words into their mouths.)

31.4 SOME PHONE ETIQUETTE FOR THE MODERN DAY

Nowadays, phones have features like text messaging, caller ID and voice mails that require some special etiquette. Here are some of them:

SMS/Text Messaging

SMS has got good traction, especially in India. The impersonal nature of SMS is a boon as well as a curse. It is easy to be more polite in an SMS than in speaking over phone, as you have time to formulate your message and there are fewer chances of getting sidetracked by synchronous conversations. It also helps you to respond back when you want.

- ▶ SMS is a good way of conveying short messages like 'I cannot attend the meeting' or some quick updates like 'the test was successful'. But obviously it is not a formal channel and you don't use it to order ten thousand units of a circuit board.
- ▶ Do not forward SMS messages recklessly.
- ▶ Be forgiving of poor spelling in SMS messages. 'That's hw u r supposed 2 deal wth it.'

Caller ID and Voice Mail

Caller IDs are godsend for us to ignore calls we don't want to take. Do use them, especially when you get a call while you are in the middle of a meeting. If you see a call coming from an unknown number or from someone you know but the call can wait, you should simply let the call pass. However, if it is a call from someone you know, do have the courtesy to return the call.

At work, set up a voice mailbox. Most Americans prefer to leave and retrieve voice mails than SMS texting. When leaving a voice message for someone, clearly identify yourself, your organization, your phone number and keep the message short. Make it a habit to check your voice mailbox frequently and retrieve messages in a timely

fashion. Sometimes, when you happen to be away from your desk for long hours, this may involve remotely calling your central voice mailbox number and logging into the system. Do return the relevant calls promptly. The key word here is relevant. As in the case of caller IDs, you need not always return a call from an unknown number.

Contacts and Organizers

During the course of your work-related activities, you may get new contacts and phone numbers. Store them away at the appropriate place—and perhaps redundantly in more than one place.

Periodically, perhaps at the beginning of each work day, review your telephone activities for that day. Are there any phone calls you need to make/return soon? Are there any action items you need to follow through further? (Especially, are there any meetings you need to schedule, because of a recent phone call?) If you are the organizer of a weekly conference call, do you need to make calls to take care of it? Have you checked your calendar for any important, pending phone calls? Remember that sometimes you may never get around to making that important phone call and this can come back to bite you.

And finally, take a few moments every once in a while to organize your contacts. How many times has it happened to you that the phone number you are looking for is the only one you don't have? The only way to safeguard against this annoying situation is to build some redundancy in your system and save a copy of it in your computer and perhaps even take a printout or e-mail it to yourself (so that you can access numbers when you travel). Don't be too quick to erase phone numbers from your contacts list. Likewise, organize the business cards you got from your contacts into a neat bundle and stash it away in a place you will remember.

31.5 MISCELLANEOUS TIPS ABOUT PHONES AND PHONE CALLS

- ▶ Never, never, never ask an international business partner for his or her personal cell phone or home phone numbers. Some people keep them a secret and even pay money to unlist their numbers from the directory. Instead, ask them how to contact him or her in case of emergency during the off hours and let them figure out a way.
- ▶ Do not communicate by 'missed call' with your international partner.
- ▶ When you are on the phone, don't multi-task.
- ▶ A corollary of the above—don't participate in conference calls while driving—even if you are using a 'hands-free' headphone. Driving in most modern cities requires total concentration on the traffic and conference calls also require a complete focus on the call. It is our opinion that you cannot do both of them well, simultaneously. Yes, the business call is important, but your safety and the safety of others around you is much more important. If you *really* must,

participate in the call, join the call in the passive 'listen only' mode and not actively take part in it.

- ▶ When abroad, obey that country's conventions and protocols on cell phone usage. Usually, it is okay to use cell phones in an already noisy environment such as airports, fast food restaurants and malls, whereas you are expected to desist from using them in quiet places like places of worship, group meetings or elegant restaurants.
- ▶ In some other places like hospitals and planes they may interfere with the radio equipments and you are not supposed to use them anyway. Please don't show off your importance to everyone around you by switching on the cell phone while the plane is still taxiing to the gate on the runway.
- ▶ Remember that it is generally not a good idea to carry on loud business calls in public (like in an airport) and letting others around listen to it. It is not only imprudent, but also very rude to the people around you.
- ▶ Use speakerphone only if you must. In such a case, inform the other persons that they are on speakerphone.



Fig. 31.1

- ▶ When giving out a phone number, say 2221 5515, don't confuse the international business partner by going 'triple two one double five one five' and so on. Most of the world does not use double, triple convention. Instead, combine two numbers at a time. (If the communication is very clear you can club three or even four numbers together) Say, for example, 'two-two, two-one, five-five, one-five'.
- ▶ Americans typically follow a 3-3-4 convention. Typically, they say 'Area code 415; 789 5672', with a pause after 415 and a pause between 789 and 5672. Or they say '415 (pause) 789 (pause) 5672'. It is a good idea to stick to this convention when you are in the USA.
- ▶ Indian numbers are somewhat non-standard, with a different number of digits for mobile numbers and landline numbers and different 'codes' for calling landlines from within India and outside India. For example, a landline number in Bangalore could be 080-25674292 while dialling from within India, whereas it would be +91-80-2567-4292 when dialling from abroad. And mobile numbers in India follow entirely different numbering conventions. Make sure you clearly say the correct number to be dialled from abroad – including the preceding international, country and area codes.
- ▶ It is illegal in many countries to record telephone conversations without the permission of the other party—but a lot of people are not aware of such legal restrictions. It is important to realize that the rest of the world expects us to follow such phone etiquette when doing business with them.
- ▶ And finally, the next time the phone rings and you are in the middle of something important, remember that you don't have to answer the darned thing!